Who Decides Idaho?

Filing, the closed primary, and the general election in a dominant-party state — from 1.03 million individual registration and vote records

Stephen Kirby · Tikor Consulting · July 2026

AI-assisted drafting and analysis review. All figures are reproducible from public-record data available through lawful request and from the open-source scripts cited below, including `scripts/verify_who_decides_id.py`*. The paper source, code, and data-acquisition recipe are public at https://github.com/skirby359/who-decides; the underlying voter file is not redistributed. Contact: kirby@tikorconsulting.com.*

Deep-red companion to `who-decides-washington.md` *and* `who-decides-new-york.md`*. Washington showed the off-year electorate is older; New York (deep blue) showed* whose *electorate ages and who is shut out of the nominating contest. Idaho completes the set from the other pole: a state where the Republican nomination process — candidate filing and then the closed May primary — produces the eventual winner of 90 of 105 legislative seats, so the question "who decides" has a sharper, more literal answer than in any two-party state. But the answer is not "the primary electorate": that electorate chose among more than one candidate in 52 of the 105 seats, and §IV decomposes the rest on two separate variables.* (Three earlier framings sit behind that sentence and all are withdrawn in place. This line called the November general "a formality" until 2026-08-11 — it is not; Democrats won 15 of 105 seats, see §V. It said the closed primary "resolves the great majority of seats" until 2026-08-15, which the paper's own seat counts contradict: 52 of 105 is 49.5%. What resolves the great majority is the nomination process, of which the primary is one of two stages. And until 2026-08-16 §IV reported that nomination cut under a definition about contestation, which is a different variable: 80 of the 105 seats still offered a choice on the November ballot. Producing the winner's nomination and settling the seat are not the same event, and the paper now measures both.) *DRAFT — pending human/editorial sign-off.* `scripts/verify_who_decides_id.py` *scrapes this paper and asserts its figures against the voter file, with the exceptions the script names in its own output; see* `electoral-health-audit-log.md`*. That gate is automated and is not the sign-off. The sign-off is a person reading the paper end to end, recorded in* `id-submission-notes.md` *§Sign-off.***

This line previously read "AI-side reproduction verified (all `verify_*` *scripts re-run, exit 0)". That formulation is worth nothing and the New York companion says so in its own front matter: a script with no assertions and no failing exit path returns 0 whatever the data says, so "exit 0" is a claim about the script, not the paper. What replaces it names the assertion, which is the thing a reader can check.*

Provenance. All figures from `data/id_vrdb.duckdb` *— Idaho's statewide voter file with history (1,029,938 registrants; individual party affiliation + age + per-election vote history incl. the primary ballot each voter pulled, all ~100% populated) — via* `scripts/diag_id_turnout_party.py` *and* `scripts/diag_id_electorate_extras.py`*. The donor layer joins Idaho Sunshine state contributions via* `scripts/match_id_voters_to_donors.py`*. Competitiveness from* `forecast_predictions`*. Each figure below traces to one of these scripts.*

Load-bearing caveats. (1) The file is the current (2026) roll, which has shrunk to 1.03M from the ~1.18M registered at the 2024 election, chiefly through list maintenance. Voters who cast a past ballot but were since purged/moved are absent, so any turnout rate computed from this file is biased high — materially: an all-voter 2024 rate comes out near 94% against the official 77.8%. The bias is larger *for high-churn groups (young, unaffiliated, movers), so even within-year cross-group rate comparisons are unreliable. This paper therefore reports composition shares only (who the electorate is), which need no registration denominator, and reports no turnout rates. See Methods. (2) Idaho publishes age, not date of birth; election-time age is approximated as* `age - (2026 - year)`*, accurate to ~1 year — fine for bands, and we never claim exact ages. (3) "UNAFF" = Idaho's unaffiliated registration; its partisan lean is never imputed.*

Abstract

In a dominant-party state the general election is rarely where governing choices are made, but "the primary decides" is too coarse an account of where they are made instead. Idaho is **63%** Republican and **12%** Democratic by registration. Using the statewide voter file for **1,029,938** registrants, with party of record and the party ballot each voter actually pulled, this paper locates the decision seat by seat and measures who is present at it. The central result is a decomposition of all **105** legislative seats in 2024 on **two** variables that the phrase "where a seat is decided" ordinarily conflates. By the stage that produced the winner's *nomination*: a **contested** Republican primary for **52** (**49.5%**); an uncontested Republican nomination for **38** more (**36.2%**); the November general for **9** (**8.6%**), where a single-filer Republican lost to a Democrat; and no Republican filing at all for the remaining **6** (**5.7%**). The eventual winner in **90 of 105** seats (**85.7%**) was therefore a Republican whose nomination was settled before November — but the primary *electorate* chose among more than one

candidate in fewer than half. By the stage at which the seat stopped being *contested*, the same seats fall very differently: **80** (**76.2%**) still offered two or more candidates on the general-election ballot, **16** (**15.2%**) were contested only in the primary, and just **9** (**8.6%**) were unopposed at every stage. The two cuts disagree about **71** seats, and that gap is the paper's sharpest single result: Idaho's dominant party settles who will hold most seats long before November without leaving the November ballot empty. A seat can be uncompetitive without being uncontested — and crossing the contestation cut against the observed margin gives the three-layer summary the two tables cannot: **105** seats, **80** offering a choice on the ballot, **8** offering a close one.

Two further findings are specific to Idaho rather than replications of the off-cycle turnout literature. First, **senior representation is nearly identical across the two parties**: Republicans and Democrats among 2024 general voters are within a fraction of a point on the 65-and-over share, **31.7%** against **31.5%** — *senior-share parity*, which contrasts with the national older-is-more-Republican pattern and with what the New York companion finds. What distinguishes Idaho's unaffiliated quarter is the senior end specifically — **21.3%** aged 65 or over against roughly 31.6% in both parties — and not the young end, where unaffiliated and Democratic voters are level at **19.6%** and **19.4%** under 30. Second, the file records the party ballot each voter pulled, so participation in the decisive primary is observed directly rather than inferred from registration: **83.4%** of 2024 primary participants took a Republican ballot. That observed measure matters because the registration-based one is contaminated by the primary itself — under Idaho Code **§ 34-411A** an unaffiliated elector who requests a Republican ballot may affiliate at the poll book, and the county clerk then records that affiliation in the statewide registration file, while a Democratic ballot carries no such conversion. Because the file is a single 2026 snapshot with no affiliation date, the unaffiliated shares reported for past primaries are **lower bounds**, tighter the closer the primary is to the snapshot. On the contaminated measure the May 2024 primary electorate is **85.2%** Republican by party of record against **62.9%** of the roll, a Republican-minus-Democratic margin of **76.8** points against **51.1** on the rolls, and its Republican-ballot voters have a median age of **63** with **46.7%** aged 65 or over. Every one of the **35** legislative districts carries a Republican registration advantage and none is near parity. The paper reports composition shares and deliberately reports no turnout rates, because a current-extract roll that has contracted from about 1.18 to 1.03 million inflates every rate.

Keywords. one-party dominance; closed primaries; nominating electorate; voter file; party registration; unaffiliated voters; uncontested elections; turnout composition; election timing; Idaho

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The question

How *many* people vote is the wrong question for understanding how a state is governed. The right one is *who* — and the question after that is *where*: at which stage of the sequence a seat is actually settled. Idaho is a dominant-party state by registration (**63% Republican, 12% Democratic, 24% unaffiliated**), and most of its officeholders are chosen before November. But "before November" covers two distinct gates, and they are not the same gate at all: the **candidate-filing deadline**, where in more than a third of seats only one Republican comes forward, and the **closed May Republican primary**, where a much narrower electorate chooses among those who did.

The short answer: **the people who actually decide Idaho are a gray, Republican, self-selected slice of an already-Republican state — where anyone decides at all.** In November the electorate is broadly representative; in the primary it is older and drawn almost entirely from one party; and in about two-fifths of seats no contested election of any kind takes place. The 24% of registrants who decline a party can enter the Republican primary, but only by becoming Republicans to do it — an affiliation requirement, not a locked door, and one that almost all of them decline to pay.

Two further findings are specific to Idaho, not a replication of the off-cycle turnout literature. First, **senior representation is nearly identical in the two parties**: Idaho's Republicans and Democrats are within a fraction of a point on the 65-and-over share — *senior-share parity*, which contrasts with the national "older-is-more-Republican" pattern and with what the New York companion found. The unaffiliated bloc is the young one, but the gap that makes it so is at the senior end — it carries ten fewer points of over-65s than either party, while being level with Democrats among the under-30s. Second, the file records the party ballot each voter actually pulled, so participation in the decisive primary is **observed rather than inferred from registration alone**. That distinction is load-bearing here rather than decorative, because the registration-based measure is partly destroyed by the act it records, for the reason set out in Section IV.

I. The midterm electorate is substantially older than the presidential electorate

Share of the general-election electorate by age band:

Election	Type	18–29	30–44	45–64	65+	median

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Nov 2024	Presidential	15.2%	23.4%	32.4%	29.0%	52
Nov 2022	Midterm	**8.6%**	20.7%	36.3%	**34.4%**	57
Nov 2020	Presidential	13.8%	23.9%	36.1%	26.3%	52
—	Registration baseline (2026)	15.2%	22.8%	30.9%	31.0%	52

As the contest shrinks (presidential → midterm), the under-30 share nearly halves (15.2% → 8.6%) and the 65+ share swells (29% → 34%); median age rises from 52 to 57. This is the classic **surge-and-decline** shape (Campbell 1960), and it is consistent with the wider salience-and-turnout literature.

What this section claims is composition, not mechanism, and the distinction is forced by Idaho's own data. It says the observed electorate becomes older as salience falls. It does not say that the whole of that change is age-specific participation *behaviour* rather than change in the registered population, because this file cannot separate the two: the historical turnout denominators are unusable, the current roll excludes everyone who has since left it, and `registration_date` resets on ordinary events (Boundary of inference; §VI). A rate-based decomposition run on reconstructed historical rolls inherits every one of those defects.

This paragraph replaced a stronger one on 2026-08-15. The section previously read "Behavior, not rolls", cited a Das-Gupta decomposition attributing the 65+ rise mostly to turnout, and said the young "choose not to vote" — while the same paper's Boundary section establishes that reconstructed historical rolls and rates cannot carry that weight. An external referee named the contradiction. The composition finding is unaffected and survives a hostile missing-voter bound (Boundary); the mechanism claim is withdrawn rather than softened.

The section heading changed at the same time, for a second reason. It read "The off-year electorate is older — Idaho replicates Washington", and this comparison is 2024 presidential against 2022 midterm: two even-year federal general elections. That is presidential-versus-midterm, not the odd-year/off-cycle timing effect Washington's companion measures — a distinction the section drew in its own parenthesis and then undid in its heading, its verb ("replicates") and its conclusion ("timing-fixable", "on-cycle remedy"). Idaho's voter file does not contain the odd-year local elections the Washington mechanism would need. The off-cycle literature — Anzia 2014; Hajnal & Trounstine 2005 — remains relevant to Idaho's local offices, which like Washington's sit off the federal calendar; it is simply not what this table measures.

II. Senior representation is the same in both parties — and that is the whole of the finding

This is where Idaho diverges sharply from New York. New York's Republican electorate is consistently the older of the two; in Idaho the two major parties carry the same senior share. Share of each party's 2024 general-election voters by age, plus median age:

Party	share 65+	share 18–29	median age
Republican	31.7%	12.7%	54
Democratic	31.5%	19.4%	50
Unaffiliated	**21.3%**	**19.6%**	**46**
Other (Lib/Con)	10.0%	23.0%	39

The Republican and Democratic electorates are within a fraction of a point on the 65+ share and only four years apart on median age. **That parity is the finding, and it is confined to the senior end.** The generational sorting that makes "older = redder" a useful heuristic nationally does not hold here: in Idaho, older = *more attached to a party at all*, not more Republican. The unaffiliated bloc carries ten fewer points of over-65s than either party (21.3% against 31.7% and 31.5%), which is what pulls its median down to 46 — and it is the reason Sections III–IV matter, since that bloc is the one that vanishes from the contest that decides.

Read the under-30 column before generalising, because it does not say what the 65+ column says. Unaffiliated and **Democratic** voters are level there — 19.6% against 19.4%, a fifth of a point apart — while Republicans sit nearly seven points below both. So on the youth measure the unaffiliated bloc is indistinguishable from the Democratic electorate, and the two-party contrast is not neutral at all.

Until 2026-08-15 this section and the abstract said the age gap was "party-neutral" and that Idaho's youth "sits in the unaffiliated bloc rather than in either party". The second half was false against the table printed directly above it, and an external referee read it there. Both claims are narrowed to the one the data carries: senior-share parity between the parties, and an unaffiliated bloc that is younger than both because it has fewer seniors — not because it has more young people than Democrats do. The narrowed claim is the more interesting one anyway, and it is asserted as a relation in `scripts/verify_who_decides_id.py` *rather than merely restated, so it cannot quietly stop being true.*

III. The unaffiliated quarter: turns out in November, absent in May

Idaho's 245,887 unaffiliated registrants (23.9% of the roll) are the recurring blind spot. Because Idaho's roll cannot support reliable turnout *rates* (Methods), we follow each bloc by its **share of the electorate** — a denominator-free measure — across the two contests:

Bloc	roll %	median age	% 65+	% 18–29	share of 2024 general electorate	share of 2024 primary electorate
Republican	62.9%	55	34.5%	12.6%	64.5%	**85.2%**
Unaffiliated	23.9%	46	22.4%	19.9%	22.6%	**5.9%**
Democratic	11.8%	50	32.4%	19.1%	11.6%	8.3%
Other	1.4%	40	11.0%	21.3%	1.3%	0.6%

The story is in the last two columns. The unaffiliated are **22.6% of the 2024 general electorate** — essentially their full 23.9% of the roll, so in November they show up. But they are only **5.9% of the May primary electorate**: a bloc that is nearly a quarter of the state, and a quarter of the November vote, casts about **one in seventeen** primary ballots.

The mechanism is an affiliation requirement, not exclusion, and the difference is worth stating precisely. Idaho's Republican primary is closed, but an unaffiliated elector is not barred from it: under Idaho Code § 34-411A they may affiliate with the party of their choice up to and including election day, by signed form or by declaring the choice to a poll worker. What they cannot do is **participate in the Republican primary while remaining unaffiliated** — affiliation is the price of admission, and it is a price that persists on the roll afterwards (§IV). So the 5.9% is not a measure of people turned away. It is a measure of how few pay that price, and — because paying it reclassifies them — it is also a lower bound (§IV).

This section, the abstract and the opening described the unaffiliated quarter as "locked out", "outside the room" and unable to enter, until 2026-08-15. An external referee pointed out that Idaho's election authorities say the opposite; checking the statute directly, § 34-411A says it in as many words, and the paper's own §IV already described the same-day affiliation mechanism the wording was denying. The institutional finding is unchanged and the wording is now the one that is harder to attack.

> **A note on the roll itself.** Idaho's registration file shrank from **~1.18M** at the November 2024 election to **~1.03M** in this 2026 snapshot — a **net decline of 148,812 registrations, 12.6%** of the 2024 total, from routine list maintenance (inactive-voter removal, change-of-address, deaths). That contraction is the reason historical turnout *rates* cannot be reconstructed from a single snapshot (Methods).
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> **Two things this figure is not.** First, it is not turnover, and it is not an upper bound on turnover: it is a difference between two stocks, so anyone who joined the roll after November 2024 is netted against someone who left. Gross departures are therefore **at least** 148,812 and could be far more. The direction of that bound was stated backwards here until 2026-08-15.
>
> Second, it is not explained by same-day registrants. This note previously attributed part of the contraction to "the non-persistence of the 121,000 voters who registered same-day on Election Day 2024" — a mechanism that was never measured and that the file can measure, because a voter who registered at the polls carries that date. Measured: **109,441 of the 121,015 election-day registrants are still on the 2026 roll, at least 90.4%**, and 109,233 of them carry a 2024 general vote record. That is a floor rather than a rate — `registration_date` records the most recent registration event, so any of them who has since moved or changed party carries a later date and is counted here as gone — so true retention is higher still. **The claim was wrong and is withdrawn**, not softened; whatever produced Idaho's roll contraction, it was not the election-day cohort failing to persist.

IV. Where seats are actually settled — and how gray the primary electorate is

The Republican nomination process produces the winner in the great majority of Idaho's legislative seats. The primary electorate does not. Neither statement is the same as saying the seat was over before November. Those are three different claims and this section separates them, because conflating them is the error the section has now made twice in opposite directions; the rest of it describes who is present at the stage that does the most work.

Two variables, not one. "Where a seat is decided" hides a distinction that Idaho's own records can settle. *When was the winner's nomination determined?* and *when did the seat stop being contested?* are different questions with different answers, and the tables below report them separately rather than blending them into a single word.

Variable 1 — the stage that produced the winner's nomination. All 105 legislative seats, 2024. Each seat is assigned by the shape of the eventual winner's own party primary:

Stage that produced the winner's nomination	seats	share
Contested Republican primary — ≥2 Republicans filed; a Republican won in November	**52**	**49.5%**
Uncontested Republican nomination — one Republican filed; that Republican won	**38**	**36.2%**
The November general — one Republican filed; a **Democrat** won	**9**	**8.6%**
No Republican filed at all — a Democrat won	**6**	**5.7%**

Read across: the eventual winner in **90 of 105 seats (85.7%)** was a Republican whose nomination was determined before the general election — **52** through a contested Republican primary and **38** through an uncontested one. That is the sense in which "the great majority" is defensible, and it is a claim about the *nomination*, not about the election. Democrats ultimately won **15**, of which **9** came against a sole Republican filer. Their own nominations were almost all uncontested in turn: **13** of the 15 drew a single Democratic filer and only **2** faced a contested Democratic primary.

Variable 2 — the stage at which the seat stopped being contested. The same 105 seats, assigned to the last stage at which more than one candidate was still on a ballot:

Last contested stage	seats	share
The November general — two or more candidates on the general-election ballot	**80**	**76.2%**
The primary — a contested primary, then an unopposed general	**16**	**15.2%**
Candidate filing — unopposed at every stage	**9**	**8.6%**

The two cuts disagree about 71 of the 105 seats, and the disagreement is the finding. Idaho's dominant party settles who will hold most seats months before November — but that is not the same as November being empty. Most Idaho voters did face a choice on the general ballot; in most cases it was a choice whose outcome was never in doubt. A seat can be uncompetitive without being uncontested, and the distinction matters precisely because the reform arguments in this literature attach to different stages.

How little of that contestation was competitive — because the second table counts ballot presence, not viability. Of the **80** seats offering two or more candidates in November, only **8** were decided by fewer than ten points and **6** more by ten to twenty; **18** ran to twenty-to-forty, **43** to forty or more, and a further **5** offered no two-party choice at all despite carrying multiple candidates. So the honest summary has three layers rather than two: **105** seats, **80** with a choice on the ballot, **8** with a close one. That is a sharper statement of this paper's thesis than either table alone, and it is the reason the 80 must not be read as a competitiveness figure — it measures *ballot access*, and only the margin column turns it into a statement about contests.

Both tables are new on 2026-08-16 and they replace a single table that carried the first one's numbers under the second one's definition. That table was headed "the decision venue" and defined as "the last stage at which more than one candidate was still in contention", but it was computed from the Republican primary's shape and the general's winner and never looked at who else was on the November ballot. A second external referee caught the mismatch, and the data is emphatic: of the **38** seats the old table assigned to candidate filing, **35 faced an opponent in November**, **32** of them a major-party opponent, and **3** were decided by a margin under ten points. Calling those "decided once the filing period closed" was wrong, and it is withdrawn rather than softened. *(The same referee suspected the six no-Republican seats had the mirror-image problem — that a contested Democratic nomination might sit behind them. Measured, they do not: all six drew a sole Democratic filer and all six were unopposed in November, so filing genuinely did settle them. That row survives the objection.)*

The first table's counts are unchanged, and its own history is worth keeping. It replaced the section's headline claim on 2026-08-15 at an earlier referee's insistence, and he was right on the paper's own numbers: 52 of 105 is 49.5%, so "the closed primary resolves the great majority of seats" was contradicted by the counts printed three paragraphs below it. His decomposition put all fifteen Democratic seats in the November column; six had no Republican filing at all, so the count that genuinely turned on the general is nine. What neither he nor this paper noticed until the following day was that the corrected table was still answering a question the surrounding prose was not asking.

Three facts describe the primary electorate itself.

The primary electorate is far more Republican than November. Party of record on the 2026 roll, by contest, as R-minus-D margin:

Contest	REP	DEM	UNAFF	R − D
Nov 2024 general	64.5%	11.6%	22.6%	+52.9
Nov 2022 general	68.6%	12.1%	18.2%	+56.5
May 2024 primary	**85.2%**	8.3%	5.9%	**+76.8**
May 2022 primary	**85.9%**	8.2%	5.3%	**+77.7**
— Registration baseline	62.9%	11.8%	23.9%	+51.1

The unaffiliated share of the electorate falls from ~24% of the roll to roughly **5–7%** of the primary; the R−D skew widens from ~+51 in November to ~+77 in the primary. **80–86% of every primary ballot cast in Idaho is a Republican ballot** — the range spans every primary cycle in the file, from 79.6% in 2026 to 86.5% in 2022.

Which of those two measures to believe, stated once. Every party column in the table above is **party of record on the 2026 roll**, not party at the time of the election. The file carries no affiliation date, so a voter who changed party at any point between the contest and June 2026 — including through the poll-book affiliation described below, but also through any ordinary change — is classified here by where they ended up. "85.2% of the 2024 primary electorate was Republican" therefore means, exactly, *85.2% of reconstructed 2024 primary participants are classified Republican on the 2026 roll*. **The ballot column has no such defect**: it records which party's ballot the voter actually took, at the time, and it is populated for 99.6–99.9% of participants. Where the two disagree, the ballot is the measurement and the registration is the residue — Republican ballots were **83.4%** of 2024 primary participants against 85.2% classified Republican, and **86.1%** in 2022 against 85.9%. This basis note was added on 2026-08-15 after an external referee observed, correctly, that the paper knew about the contamination in one direction (§IV's conversion mechanism) and had not applied it to ordinary party switching.

Two denominators appear in this section, a fraction of a point apart, so which one a figure uses is stated rather than left to be inferred. The 79.6 / 86.5 range above is the Republican share of ballots whose party choice is recorded. The falling series later in this section — 86.1% / 83.4% / 79.5% — is the Republican share of all primary participants, including the 0.1–0.4% of them (436 to 1,379 voters a cycle) whose ballot choice `id-primary-ballot-choice-blank` *records that the file does not carry. Both are asserted; neither is wrong; they are not interchangeable. That those blanks are the source's rather than our loader's was checked against the raw export rather than inferred from the loaded table — the same claim shape was false for Washington's PDC direction flag, where the gap turned out to be our own extraction.*

The R−D column is computed on **unrounded** shares, so it need not equal the difference of the two printed columns. The May 2024 row is the one where that shows: 85.17 − 8.34 = 76.82, against 85.2 − 8.3 = 76.9 read off the table. The unrounded figure is the one printed.

The underlying counts, and how they were checked. Of the 105 legislative seats, **99 drew a Republican primary in 2024** (the other six are the safe-Democratic seats where no Republican filed); of those 99, just **52 (53%) were contested** and **47 (47%) had a single Republican on the ballot** (`scripts/diag_id_primary_contested.py` , reconciled seat-by-seat against the 35-district / 105-seat frame — every race maps 1:1 to a seat, no duplicates; the contested counts match Ballotpedia's independent tallies cycle-by-cycle, exact for 2022 and 2024 and within ±2 for 2016 and 2018). Those 47 single-candidate primaries did not all settle a seat: **9 of them were won by a Democrat in November**, while all 52 contested-primary seats went Republican. That is the arithmetic behind the decomposition above, and behind the narrower statement that the binding choice was candidate *filing* for **38 of the 90 Republican-held seats, 42%**.

Contestation rose to a 2022 peak and then fell. Across the loaded cycles the Republican legislative-primary contested rate runs **36% (2016) → 43% (2018) → 68% (2022) → 53% (2024)**. 2022 was the first post-redistricting cycle; 2024 sits a sixth below it and still well above 2016. (2020 is not comparable: the SoS published that mail-only cycle's legislative results at county level only.) With four comparable observations and a missing 2020, **this paper claims no trend** — only that the contested share is materially higher in the 2020s than in the 2010s and that it did not continue rising. Democratic legislative primaries, by contrast, are almost never contested (2–11% across these cycles) — the mirror image of one-party dominance.

Two things came out of this paragraph on 2026-08-15. It said the rate had "roughly doubled across the decade", which its own series contradicts on any endpoint reading: 36 → 53 is 1.4×, and the 1.9× is 2016 to the 2022 peak, from which the series then falls. And it attributed the 2022 peak to "the height of the state GOP's traditional-vs-hardline fights" — a post-hoc political reading with no source, which is now dropped rather than left standing on assertion. The shape of the series is asserted in code (`rprim_peak_ratio`, `rprim_endpoint_ratio`), because a trend word has no numeric token a coverage gate can catch.

The primary electorate is older than even the Republican rolls. Comparing all Republican registrants to those who actually pulled a Republican ballot in 2024:

Group	18–29	30–44	45–64	65+	median
Republican registrants (all roll)	12.6%	20.4%	32.5%	34.5%	55
Republican-ballot primary voters, 2024	**5.0%**	14.2%	34.1%	**46.7%**	**63**

The people who nominate Idaho's officeholders are a gray subset of an already-red party: **median age 63, nearly half of them 65+.**

When today's unaffiliated registrants voted in a past primary, they mostly pulled the Democratic ballot — but this table cannot be read as a trend. Ballot choice among voters who are unaffiliated *on the 2026 roll*:

Primary	→ REP	→ DEM	→ nonpartisan	years before the snapshot
May 2022	27.7%	52.6%	19.0%	4.1
May 2024	9.7%	52.5%	37.5%	2.1
May 2026	**1.7%**	**65.6%**	32.6%	0.1

The Republican column is an artifact of the snapshot, not a behavioural trend, and this is the paper's central measurement caveat. Two statutes do the work, and the paper cited only the first of them until 2026-08-15. **Idaho Code § 34-904A** governs *eligibility*: an elector who has designated a party affiliation may vote only in that party's primary, which is what makes the Republican primary closed. **Idaho Code § 34-411A** supplies the *mechanism and its trace*: an unaffiliated elector may affiliate up to and including election day, may do so by declaring the choice to a poll worker, who records it in the poll book — and "after the primary election, the county clerk shall record the party affiliation so recorded in the poll book as part of such elector's record within the voter registration system." That last clause is the measurement problem in the statute's own words: **the act of voting a Republican ballot writes itself into the field this paper reads.** Requesting a Democratic ballot does not affiliate anyone, because the Idaho Democratic Party admits unaffiliated voters. `voters.party` is a **single current snapshot** — the raw file carries a party description and **no affiliation date** — so an unaffiliated voter who entered the Republican primary is, by construction, no longer unaffiliated when we look.

An external referee flagged the § 34-904A citation as misplaced. He was right that § 34-411A is where the same-day mechanism lives, and it is a better citation than the one it replaces because it also contains the registration-system recording clause the caveat depends on. He was not right that § 34-904A is the wrong statute for this passage — it is the closure rule the whole section is about — so both are now cited, each for what it actually says.

The data shows exactly that signature and nothing else explains it. The Republican column falls monotonically with distance from the snapshot (27.7 → 9.7 → 1.7) while the Democratic column does not (52.6 → 52.5 → 65.6). Among today's unaffiliated voters who pulled a **Republican** ballot in 2022, **55.8%** carry a registration date *after* that primary — they re-registered, reverting to unaffiliated — against **15.2%** of those who pulled a Democratic ballot. And voters who are Republican today pulled a Republican ballot in 97.3 / 96.9 / 97.7% of cases across the three primaries, a concordance that is definitional rather than behavioural.

What this costs the finding. The 5.9% unaffiliated share of the May 2024 primary electorate is not a measurement of unaffiliated participation; it is a measurement of unaffiliated *non-participation in the Republican primary*, since participation there removes a voter from the category. The honest estimates are the 2026 figures, closest to the snapshot: unaffiliated registrants are **7.3%** of that primary electorate. The 2024 and 2022 figures are **lower bounds**, and the conversion is unobservable from this source, so the gap cannot be closed with the data at hand — a defect the New York companion avoids because enrollment there must precede the primary by months and is bounded at 0.7–1.4%.

The direction of the lock is also not what an earlier reading suggested. The Republican share of *all* primary ballots cast falls across the three cycles — **86.1% (2022), 83.4% (2024), 79.5% (2026)** — while the Democratic ballot share rises.

Whatever is happening to Idaho's one-party primary, it is not tightening on this measure.

V. Every district carries a Republican registration advantage

Districts by **registration advantage** (Republican % − Democratic % of registrants):

Level (n)	R+40 or more	R+20 to 40	R+5 to 20	Within 5 points	Any D advantage
Congressional (2)	**2**	0	0	0	0
Legislative (35)	**27**	4	4	**0**	**0**

Both U.S. House seats and every one of the 35 legislative districts carry a Republican registration advantage; **none is within five points, and none advantages Democrats.**

The bands were labelled "Safe R / Likely R / Lean R / Competitive" until 2026-08-15. An external referee objected that those are election-outcome labels attached to a registration measure that demonstrably does not map onto outcomes — the paragraph immediately below says so — and he is right. Cook-style names import a prediction the measure cannot make. The bands are now named for what they are: intervals of R-minus-D registration.

Registration advantage is not an outcome, and here it is decisively not one. In the November 2024 general, Democrats won **15 of Idaho's 105 legislative seats** (90 R / 15 D, matching the seated 2025–26 legislature), including seats this table places in its widest band. Of the 47 seats whose Republican primary drew a single candidate, **nine were won by a Democrat in November** — so for those the choice was settled by the general, not at filing. An earlier version of this section wrote that "where the general election cannot change an outcome" the primary is the only decisive contest; that inference does not survive its own state's results, and the companion safe-seat paper withdrew a stronger version of it on *observed margins*, which are better evidence than registration. It is not reinstated here on weaker evidence.

What the table does support is narrower: **Idaho has no district where registration alone would lead one to expect a Democratic win**, which is why the Republican nomination process is where most seats are resolved (§IV) — a claim about where the action is concentrated, not about what November can do. The three-state superlative that stood here is also withdrawn: Washington publishes no party registration at all, so no comparable registration-advantage map exists for it, and comparing this table to the safe-seat paper's observed margins compares two different measures.

VI. Recently-dated registration records are younger and less Republican

Party mix and age of the registrants on the current roll, grouped by the year their `registration_date` falls in:

Registration dated	registrants	% REP	% DEM	% UNAFF	median age at that date
2008	22,559	66.4%	5.3%	28.0%	45
2012	30,843	71.5%	11.8%	15.9%	47
2016	61,465	65.5%	12.1%	21.2%	46
2020	153,710	60.8%	12.2%	25.1%	43
2022	97,593	64.8%	11.3%	21.8%	44
2024	263,322	**57.5%**	12.4%	**28.3%**	**35**

These are not cohorts, and the table must not be read as one. `registration_date` is the date of a voter's most recent registration *event*, not their first. Idaho writes a new date on an address change, a party change — including the § 34-411A poll-book affiliation of Section IV — and an election-day registration. The rows are therefore structurally different populations rather than successive intakes of new voters: a record dated 2008 belongs to someone who has avoided every registration-resetting event for eighteen years, and a record dated 2024 mixes genuinely new registrants with movers, party changers, poll-book affiliates and re-registrants. Of the registrants dated 2024, **36.3% had already voted in an earlier election**; of those dated 2022, **43.7%** had. Both are floors, because the file's vote history reaches back only to 2020, so a 2024 registrant who last voted in 2018 is indistinguishable from a genuinely new one. The 2008–2020 rows cannot be cleaned at all for the same reason, and the 263,322 registrants dated 2024 — a quarter of the roll in one year — is a registration-event count, not a count of new voters.

Removing the *detectably* re-registered does not repair this, and the paper does not claim it does: the filter cannot see a voter registered before 2020 who did not vote in the observed history, an address change by someone with no prior observed vote, or a party change. It is reported because it shows the direction is not an artifact of the detectable part of the contamination — dropping those registrants makes the newest group **younger, not older** (median age at registration 35 → **32**, against 45–47 a decade earlier) and leaves the Republican share where it was (57.5% → **57.7%**, against the high-60s and low-70s of earlier rows). The dilution flows to **unaffiliated, not Democratic**: excluding detectable re-registrants, the 2024 unaffiliated share rises 28.3% → **29.8%** while the Democratic share falls 12.4% → **10.7%**. Across the full table the Democratic share sits near 12% and the unaffiliated share climbs to 28%.

So what the table shows is descriptive and bounded: voters whose most recent registration event is recent are younger, and more often unaffiliated, than voters whose recorded registration event is much older. That is interesting — it is consistent with an unaffiliated bloc that is growing and young, which §III showed pays an affiliation cost to reach the contest that decides — but it is not a measurement of who is entering Idaho's electorate, and nothing here licenses a projection.

Three claims were removed from this section on 2026-08-15, after an external referee pointed out that they all rest on a cohort reading the section itself had already disavowed two paragraphs earlier: "a leading indicator" (the heading), "new registrants are younger and less Republican", and "the rolls are slowly loosening the two-party grip". The concession about `registration_date` had been added in an earlier round without propagating to the conclusions built on top of it — the recurring failure mode in this series, where a correction lands in one paragraph and the paragraph it invalidates survives. The figures are unchanged; only what may be inferred from them is.

VII. The donor class is not the electorate — and leans against the rolls

Matching the roll to Idaho Sunshine state-campaign contributions links **23,613 registered voters to 114,806 donations ($13.64M)**. The match uses the full-name key alone (last name + full first name + ZIP5), the specification adopted across this series on 2026-07-27 after a stratified blinded validation measured it at 100% precision (120/120) while initial-based keys ran 48–72%; see the donor-class companion, Appendix F. The restriction buys that precision at a cost worth stating where the findings are read rather than in a methods note: it **discards 11–19% of matched donors, who are younger and less Democratic than those retained**, so some part of the age and party skews below is selection rather than measurement. The superseded all-tier figures are the more conservative ones and are reported in the companion. Characterized by the donor's own party of record:

Party	donors	donor share	reg share	skew	$ share
Republican	15,645	66.3%	62.9%	+3.4	72.2%
Democratic	5,097	21.6%	11.8%	**+9.8**	20.0%
Unaffiliated	2,735	11.6%	23.9%	**−12.3**	7.6%
Other	136	0.6%	1.4%	−0.9	0.2%

Even in a state this red, the donor class **over-represents registered Democrats** — they are 12% of the roll but 22% of donors and give 20% of the money, nearly double their registration weight — while the unaffiliated quarter is again nearly absent (12% of donors, 8% of dollars). Republicans still supply the plurality of money in absolute terms, as a 63%-Republican state must, but relative to their numbers the *most* over-represented donors are Democrats.

That over-representation is heavily concentrated among donors to three ballot-measure committees, one of which is this paper's own subject. Reclaim Idaho, Idahoans for Open Primaries and Idahoans United for Women and Families together drew gifts from **5,522 of the 23,613 matched donors (23.4%)**; Reclaim Idaho alone is the largest recipient in the Sunshine layer by gift count, with 36,490 person-gifts. Excluding donors who gave to any of the three, the Democratic share of matched donors falls from **21.6% to 16.5%** and the Republican share rises from 66.3% to 72.5% — so the +9.8-point Democratic over-representation becomes **+4.6**. It does not vanish, and the direction of Finding 3 stands. But *Idahoans for Open Primaries* is the Proposition 1 campaign this paper analyses in "What it means", and *Reclaim Idaho* is its parent organisation, so a material part of the measured donor-class tilt sits with the mobilisation the paper's own conclusion is about. That is a circularity, and it is reported here rather than left for a reader to find.

This paragraph said "more than half of that over-representation comes from" those three committees until 2026-08-15. Excluding everyone who ever gave to them changes the donor population — it does not decompose the original skew into causal parts, and *the people excluded differ from those retained in more ways than the exclusion criterion. The figures are unchanged; the verb is now the one the design supports.*

The donor class is also **grayer and more concentrated** than the electorate:

- **Age.** 51% of matched donors are 65+, versus 31% of the roll and 33% of 2024 general voters; the under-30 share is 2.1% versus 15% of the roll. (All three are computed on current-roll age, so they share one basis; the age-at-election figures in Section I are not interchangeable with them.) On that same basis the donor class is **not** the oldest layer measured here — the closed-primary electorate is at least as old: 51.9% of 2024 primary voters are 65+ (51.8% of Republican-ballot voters, 52.0% of 2022 primary voters), against 51.3% of matched donors, all four at median age 65. Donors and primary voters are effectively the same age; both are twenty points older than the roll.
- **Concentration.** The top 1% of matched donors supply **40%** of the matched dollars; the top 10% supply **71%**.
- **Geography.** Ada County (Boise) accounts for **50.3%** of matched donor dollars against **29.3%** of the roll — **1.72×** its registration weight. (On donors rather than dollars it is 37.3%, or 1.28×, so the concentration is in gift size more than in donor counts.) The bare 50% stood alone here until 2026-08-15, which reads as more geographically extreme than it is: Ada is also Idaho's largest county on the roll. The ratio is the measure the donor-class companion already uses for county concentration, so this is now consistent across the series as well as more honest — the money mirror of the population-vs-influence gap seen in New York (Manhattan) and Washington (Seattle).
- **Where the money sits.** Donor party mix tracks registration advantage. Grouping the 35 districts by the same bands used in Section V, the 27 districts at R+40 or more hold 14,594 donors who are **78% Republican / 13% Democratic**, while the eight districts between R+5 and R+40 hold 9,019 donors at a far more balanced **47% / 35%**. Those eight are where the two parties' donor bases meet — but note that none of them is within five points, so "smaller Republican advantage" is all this says; they were called "competitive-adjacent" here until 2026-08-15, which is the same outcome-semantics problem §V's band names had.

Crossover — where the money goes. Idaho Sunshine carries no party on the recipient record, but recipient party can be reconstructed from data on hand (the Secretary of State candidate roster plus party/committee name patterns), which resolves the recipient for **51% of matched donors and 41% of matched dollars** (`scripts/backfill_id_recipient_party.py`). Among donors whose money reached a party-resolvable recipient:

Donor's registration	→ gave only to D	→ gave only to R	mixed
Republican	19.1%	79.0%	1.9%
Democratic	**94.6%**	3.0%	2.3%
Unaffiliated	**77.1%**	20.5%	2.3%

Registered Democrats are near-monolithic donors (95% give only to Democrats — the same loyalty seen in New York), and unaffiliated donors lean nearly **4:1 Democratic** among the resolvable. Republicans predominantly fund Republicans (79%).

Missingness is not uniform across these rows, and it decides which of them survive. Recipient party resolves for **50.9%** of Republican donors, **58.6%** of Democratic donors and only **39.0%** of unaffiliated donors — the row with the strongest apparent tilt is the least resolved. The paper's own explanation for the unresolved pool (local Republican candidates and R-aligned PACs absent from the roster, so it skews Republican) applies to *every* donor group, not only to Republicans. Assigning every unresolved donor in a group to Republican-only giving — the hostile assignment for a Democratic-tilt claim — gives:

Donor's registration	resolved	D-only, observed	D-only under the hostile bound	R-only under the hostile bound	direction
Registered Republican	50.9%	19.1%	9.7%	89.3%	— (the 19.1% is an upper bound)
Registered Democratic	58.6%	94.6%	**55.4%**	43.2%	**survives**
Registered unaffiliated	39.0%	77.1%	30.1%	69.0%	**does not survive**

So **Democratic donor loyalty is direction-safe and the unaffiliated Democratic tilt is not.** The unaffiliated row is reported as descriptive: among unaffiliated donors whose recipients can be resolved, giving runs about 4:1 Democratic, and a hostile assignment of the unresolved 61% reverses that. Nothing here says the tilt is false — the hostile bound is deliberately extreme — only that this design cannot rule its reversal out.

Both bounds were added on 2026-08-15. The section previously called the Democratic loyalty and the unaffiliated tilt "the robust, direction-safe reads", having already conceded in the sentence before that non-random missingness inflates the Republican row. An external referee pointed out that the concession applies to the unaffiliated row too and asked for the party-specific bound. It was computed and one of the two claims did not survive it.

Boundary of inference

- **Age is imputed from a single integer.** Idaho gives current age, not DOB, so election-time ages are ±1 year and we report only bands and medians, never exact ages. This cannot manufacture the effects shown — the primary/general and cohort gaps are far larger than a one-year imputation error.
- **How complete each reconstructed electorate is, and what that bounds.** A "reconstructed" electorate here is the set of *current* registrants carrying a vote record for that election. Everyone who has since left the roll is absent from it by construction, so the right question is how many that is — and the Secretary of State's certified ballot counts answer it directly:

election	ballots cast (SoS)	reconstructed	coverage	65+ share, measured	65+ share, bounded
Nov 2024	917,469	898,877	**98.0%**	29.0%	**28.4 – 30.5%**
Nov 2022	599,493	571,868	**95.4%**	34.4%	**32.8 – 37.4%**
Nov 2020	878,527	647,029	**73.6%**	26.3%	**19.4 – 45.7%**

Two of those ballot counts were wrong until 2026-08-15 — 2024 read 917,608 and 2022 read 595,602, against the Secretary of State's 917,469 and 599,493. An external referee caught it against the SoS's current voter-statistics table. They are now pinned, with source and retrieval date, in `reference/id_sos_turnout_history_2026-08-15.csv`, and read from there rather than typed into the verifier. The verifier could not have caught this and no verifier of its design can: asserting a paper against a constant checks the paper, and says nothing about whether the constant matches the world. Worse, the 2022 count was probed — against the same wrong literal, so the probe compared a number to itself and passed forever; and the 2024 count appeared only inside a regex anchor, where a figure looks probed and is not. Both shapes are fixed. The correction moves 2022's coverage from 96.0% to 95.4% and its bound from 33.0–37.0 to 32.8–37.4; the 2024 row's coverage and bound are unchanged at this precision.

The bound is arithmetic, not a model: the missing voters can be at worst all 65+ or none of them. **For 2022 and 2024 it is narrow enough that Section I's finding survives it** — the two intervals do not overlap, so the 65+ share genuinely rises as salience falls, whoever the missing voters were. **For 2020 it is not**, and Section I's 2020 row should be read as indicative only. That row is the one place in this paper where roll attrition is large enough to carry the result.

- **Survivorship — why this paper reports no turnout rates.** The 2026 roll (1.03M) is smaller than the ~1.18M registered at the 2024 election, because Idaho purges inactive registrations. (Idaho's extract carries no active/inactive flag, so we cannot confirm the two figures are on the same base; the ~13% gap is a net change between two stocks — **a lower bound on gross departures**, since anyone who joined since is netted against someone who left — and it is not turnover. It was described here as an upper bound on turnover until 2026-08-15, which inverts what a stock difference can support. The clause attributing part of the gap to the churn of the 121,015 election-day registrants was removed at the same time: at least 90.4% of them are still on the roll, see §III.) Dividing past voters by this shrunken roll inflates every turnout rate: our all-voter 2024 general rate is ~94% against the official **77.8%** (917,469 ballots / 1,178,750 registered, Idaho SoS), and 2020 even computes above 100% — voters who re-registered after 2020 carry a later `registration_date`, dropping out of the denominator while staying in the numerator. The bias is not uniform (larger for the young, unaffiliated, and movers), so cross-group rate comparisons are unreliable too. We therefore report **composition shares** — each group's share of the actual electorate — throughout, which need no registration denominator.
- **And within that bound, the bias runs *against* the gray finding.** The table above says how much room the missing voters have; this says which way they lean. Comparing Washington's September-2023 and 2026 roll snapshots — Idaho retains no prior snapshot, and a departed voter can only be aged from one — the 504,103 voters who left the rolls are **33.1% 65+ against 23.9% of the 4,782,028 retained**. Attrition dominated by mortality is a general mechanism, so

reconstructing a past electorate from a current roll *under-counts* its oldest members. The true past electorates were, if anything, grayer than measured here: the age findings sit toward the low end of their intervals, not the middle.

- **This is a claim about composition and closure, not ideological extremism.** Sides, Tausanovitch, Vavreck & Warshaw (2020) find primary electorates are not dramatically more extreme than their party's rank-and-file, and that openness rules do not change that — a result that rebuts a *polarization* argument. It does not bear on the argument here, which is about *who takes part* (one party, older, the unaffiliated bloc almost absent) and what it costs them to, not about the ideology of those who show up. We make no claim that Idaho's primary voters are more extreme than other Republicans.
- **The donor layer here is state (Idaho Sunshine) by design.** It characterizes the people who fund Idaho's *state* campaigns — the relevant layer for state electoral health. (Idaho's **federal** FEC contributions were since loaded too — 770,765 rows / $76.2M outflow + inflow, with 23,303 FEC voter↔donor matches on the full-name key. The cross-state comparison in `cross-state-fec-money.md` §F5 uses the **pooled** Idaho match instead — both money systems in one table, 41,136 donors — and its mix D 20% / R 67% / O 13% closely tracks the Sunshine-only mix below. The age skew survives the matcher-bias re-weighting in ID as in WA/NY.) Recipient party is not in the feed; it is reconstructed for ~51% of matched donors (candidate roster + committee-name patterns), so the crossover table above is limited to party-resolvable recipients and the majority-party crossover rate is an upper bound (see §VII).
- **Lean is never imputed for the unaffiliated.** Every "unaffiliated" figure is a registration fact, not an inferred partisanship.

What it means

Idaho is the deep-red pole of this series. Washington showed the off-year electorate is older; New York showed the shrinkage is party-shaped and excludes a young unaffiliated bloc; Idaho shows what happens when the general election is not where most seats are resolved. **In 2024 the Republican nomination process produced the winner of 90 of Idaho's 105 legislative seats — but the venue was split: 52 at a contested Republican primary and 38 at candidate filing, while Democrats took the remaining 15 in November, nine of them by beating a single-filer Republican.** The voters present at the stage that does the most work were substantially older than the presidential electorate and than the registration base: median 63, with 46.7% aged 65 or over. And a quarter of the state, growing and young, can reach that stage only by taking a party label first.

(Two phrases here restated an inference §V withdraws, and are corrected as of 2026-08-11: "in districts where the general cannot overturn it" and "the only contest that counts". §V records why — Democrats won 15 of 105 legislative seats in November 2024, and nine of the 47 single-candidate Republican primaries were won by a Democrat, so the general demonstrably can change the outcome and the primary is not the only contest that counts. Both sat in this conclusion, which is outside every coverage span, while the section they contradict was gated.)

The obvious remedies are institutional: open the primary, or move the decisive contest onto the high-turnout November calendar. Idaho has recently weighed and rejected the first. **Proposition 1 (2024)** — which would have replaced the closed primary with a single top-four open primary and added ranked-choice voting in November — **lost 69.6% to 30.4%** (269,960 Yes to 618,753 No, Idaho SoS).

This paper cannot say which voters produced that result, or why. Proposition 1 was decided in the November general — the electorate this paper's own §III shows returns the unaffiliated bloc to roughly its registration weight. They were not shut out of that decision, and no individual-level Proposition 1 vote is linked here to age or registration party. The No majority is consistent with Republican primary voters defending the closed primary, with unaffiliated voters declining it, with Democrats declining it, with hostility to ranked-choice voting specifically, with objection to the two reforms being bundled, or with some mixture. The result is reported; the mechanism is not identified.

What stood here until 2026-08-15 was a stronger claim: that the result "illustrates [the paper's] mechanism", and that Idaho is a self-reinforcing equilibrium in which "the people currently outside the room do not, from outside it, have the numbers to open the door". An external referee identified this as the paper's most serious interpretive overreach, and it is — it argues against §III on the paper's own evidence, since the venue that rejected Proposition 1 is precisely the one where §III finds the excluded bloc is not excluded. The paragraph is withdrawn rather than hedged. What survives is narrower and still worth saying: Idaho's decisive stages are the filing deadline and a closed primary whose electorate is twenty years older than the roll, and the reform that would have changed the second of those was put to the voters and defeated.

Related work

This paper documents, with unusually rich individual-level data, mechanisms that are largely established; its contribution is the measurement, the senior-share parity between the two parties, and the separation of nomination stage from contestation stage — not the discovery of the mechanisms. It sits in these literatures:

- **The one-party primary as the real election.** V.O. Key, *Southern Politics in State and Nation* (1949) — in a one-party polity the dominant party's primary is the decisive contest; the general ratifies it. This paper is a modern, individual-level instance.
- **Surge-and-decline / turnout composition by salience.** Campbell, "Surge and Decline" (1960); Wolfinger & Rosenstone, *Who Votes?* (1980); Leighley & Nagler, *Who Votes Now?* (2013). Section I's presidential→midterm falloff is this.
- **Off-cycle / election-timing and representation.** Anzia, *Timing and Turnout* (2014); Hajnal & Trounstine (2005); Kogan, Lavertu & Peskowitz (2018, on school boards); Einstein, Palmer, Hamilton & Singer, "Age and Homeownership Drive the Local Turnout Gap," *Urban Affairs Review* (2025) — the closest analog to the age result. Motivates the on-cycle remedy.
- **Primary-electorate representativeness (the tension).** Sides, Tausanovitch, Vavreck & Warshaw, "On the Representativeness of Primary Electorates" (2020) — primaries are not dramatically more *extreme*; distinguished here (our claim is composition/closure, not extremism).
- **Independents / the unaffiliated.** Klar & Krupnikov, *Independent Politics* (2016).
- **Voter-file / individual-level method.** Ansolabehere & Hersh, "Validation…" (2012); Hersh, *Hacking the Electorate* (2015). On the roll-churn caveat: Feder & Miller, "The Racial Burden of Voter List Maintenance Errors," *Science Advances* (2020).
- **The donor class.** Bonica, DIME / "Mapping the Ideological Marketplace" (2014); Schlozman, Verba & Brady, *The Unheavenly Chorus* (2012); Hill & Huber, "…the Contemporary Donorate" (2017, on donors' older skew); Grumbach, Sahn & Staszak (2022).
- **The reform just rejected.** Idaho Proposition 1 (2024), top-four open primary + ranked-choice voting, defeated 69.6%–30.4% (Idaho SoS).

Methods & reproducibility

```
# 1. Load the Idaho voter file -> data/id_vrdb.duckdb (voters + voter_participation)
python scripts/load_id_voters.py

# 2. Turnout by age x party + the closed-primary flagship (Sections I-IV)
python scripts/diag_id_turnout_party.py

# 2b. Contested vs uncontested primaries (Section IV) - SoS 2024 primary canvass
python scripts/diag_id_primary_contested.py

# 3. Donor class x party (Section VII) - resolve recipient party (crossover),
#    then match; writes committee_party_override + voter_donor_affiliation_state.
#    --source state is the Sunshine layer this section reports; --source fec builds
#    the federal panel used by the cross-state comparison. Both default to the
#    full-name key (the primary specification).
STATE=ID python scripts/backfill_id_recipient_party.py
STATE=ID python scripts/match_id_voters_to_donors.py --source state

# 4. Electorate extras: unaffiliated bloc, decomposition, cohort trend,
#    safe-seat map, donor-mix x competitiveness (Sections I, III, V, VI, VII)
python scripts/diag_id_electorate_extras.py
```

Source: `data/raw/id/id_statewide_voter_history_20260629.csv` (Idaho SoS statewide voter file with history, 2026-06-29 export; public record). Party buckets: REP / DEM / UNAFF (unaffiliated) / OTHER (Libertarian + Constitution). All headline numbers above are re-derivable by running the scripts in this block.